

Three doctors from Bangalore, suspected to be part of the car-bombing plot, may well represent the 'Indian hand' of global terror

■ By Aditi Khanna in London and Stephen David in Bangalore

It's being called the Physician's Plot—six doctors and a laboratory assistant of a suspected Al-Qaeda sleeper cell plotted to set off bombs in central London. However, the suspected involvement of at least three Indian doctors from a middle class family in Bangalore has stunned the world. It is suspected that Kafeel Ahmed, a doctor at the Royal Alexandria Hospital near Glasgow, was the driver of the Jeep Cherokee which rammed into the arrival lounge of Glasgow international airport on July 29. The cylinders failed to detonate and only Kafeel sustained serious burn injuries. Also detained for questioning are his cousins Haneef, an Australia-based doctor and Sabeel, a doctor from Cheshire. Police suspect the Jeep plot was a desperate Plan B after vehicle borne improvised explosive devices (VBEDs)—cans of highly inflammable gasoline and propane, triggered off by a mobile phone—placed in two Mercedes Benz cars failed to detonate outside a night club in central London the previous day. Had the fuel-air bombs successfully ignited into a super-hot fireball filled with roofing nails, casualties were almost a certainty among the 500 or so patrons who partied late at the 1,700-person occupancy nightclub that best symbolises London's vibrant night life scene.

Other plotters—dubbed the "Doctors of Death"—include a Cheshire-based Jordanian neurologist, Mohammed Asha, and his wife, Marwah, an Iraqi national Dr Bilal Abdulla, who worked at the Royal Alexandra Hospital in Paisley and two unnamed Saudi junior doctors, also working at the same hospital. They are believed to have purchased gas canisters from a retail store and then packed them with nails and petrol. Police used the mobile phones in the unexploded cars to trace the accused in the chilling run-up to July 7, the second anniv-

ersary of London's biggest terror attacks. None of the suspects in the new plot have been formally charged, and evidence against Haneef and Sabeel seem circumstantial. If proved guilty, Kafeel could well be the first India-born terrorist after the 2005 arrest of Hindu convert Dhiren Barot aka Essa al-Hindi. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh once described India's impeccable record of being a country with 150 million Muslims, but not one in the ranks of Al-Qaeda. His contention may now well be in jeopardy.

The India-born Barot, 36, whose Gujarati parents migrated to the UK from East Africa, scouted potential targets in the US and the UK for Al-Qaeda attacks before being sentenced to life imprisonment in a British prison last year. Barot's macabre, 39-page "gas limos project" envisaged blowing up limousines with propane gas cylinders and shrapnel to maim civilians. It was fortunately nipped in the bud, but this new plot has re-ignited fears of radicalisation of Indian Muslims abroad.

DOCTORS 0



THE ORIGINAL PLAN :
1 Police tow away the Mercedes in London

THE ATTACK

1. LONDON BOMB JUNE 29, 2007, FRIDAY

Two cars filled with a lethal mix of gasoline, propane and nails were discovered in Central London. Police used call data of cell phones, used as triggering devices, to unravel the plot.

2. GLASGOW AIRPORT JUNE 30, 2007, SATURDAY

A Jeep Cherokee packed with propane is driven into the airport's arrival terminal.



KAFEEL AHMED, 27 is believed to be a key plotter, drove the propane and gasoline loaded Jeep into Glasgow airports arrival terminal after the car bombs failed to explode. The doctor, who sustained 90 per cent burns in the attack, is now recuperating in a hospital. Born and raised in Bangalore, he worked at the Royal Alexandria Hospital in Paisley near Glasgow airport.